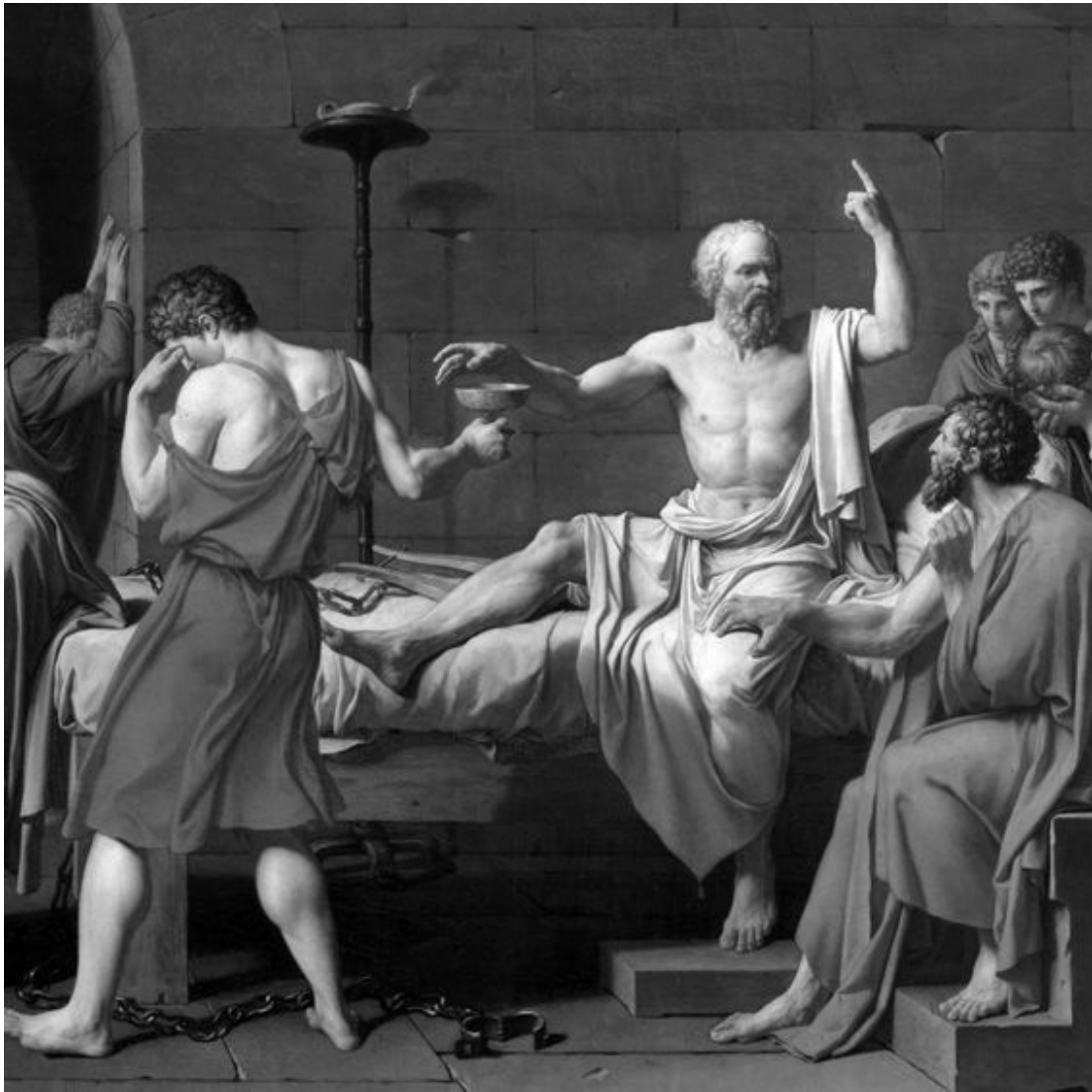


The life unexamined



Socrates wrote nothing, founded no school and had only a small group of followers, mainly young students. Yet he was well known in Athens for simply walking around the city engaging people in discussion, and was to become regarded as one of the greatest of all philosophers. Not everyone appreciated his ideas at the time, however: popular dramatists lampooned him as a figure of fun, while the establishment viewed him with suspicion for challenging conventional opinions. He was for a time dismissed as a sophist – a mere professional debater – but eventually he was accused of corrupting the morals of young people and not believing in the city gods.

Tried and found guilty, he was offered the chance to renounce his philosophical enquiries to avoid the death sentence, but chose instead to drink the hemlock offered to him, saying that the life unexamined is not worth living. One of his followers, the young Plato, wrote a moving account of his trial and death in the *Apologia*, and through his other writings preserved Socrates's ideas for posterity.